

STUDENT FIELD GUIDE

44 Places to Find Property Below Market

Every source, what it is, and a step-by-step lesson on how to work it this week.

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START HERE

How to use this guide

This guide lists 44 places investors find properties below market value. Each one gets its own one-page lesson: what it is, why deals come from it, how to work it step by step, what to say, and one thing to do this week.

Don't try all 44 at once. Pick two or three that fit your market and your schedule, work them for 90 days, and track your results. Consistency on a few sources beats dabbling in many.

1. Pick your sources

Choose one free source (like county records), one relationship source (like a realtor or wholesaler), and one list. That's your starting system.

2. Stack your lists

An owner who shows up on two or three lists (absentee *and* tax delinquent *and* code violations) is far more likely to sell. Work those leads first.

3. Follow up

Most deals close after the fourth or fifth contact, not the first. Put every lead in your CRM with a follow-up date.

4. Bring it to class

Bring your lists and your questions to the live Residential Investing sessions on Tuesdays and Wednesdays. We'll work them together.

DO IT THE RIGHT WAY

Calls and texts

Scrub phone numbers against the Do Not Call registry and follow federal and state rules on calling and texting. Texting often requires prior consent. When in doubt, mail first.

Foreclosure and licensing rules

Many states, including California, have special rules for buying from owners in foreclosure, and for paying referral fees. Check your state's rules and use an attorney and title company.

Treat people with respect

Many sources here involve hard moments: a death, a divorce, a foreclosure. Lead with care, give people time, and make offers that genuinely help.

Fair housing

Market to everyone in an area the same way. Never target or exclude owners based on race, religion, national origin, family status, disability or any protected class.

This guide is educational, not legal or financial advice. Rules, record names and access differ by state and county. Confirm local requirements before you act.

THE FULL LIST

All 44 sources

Grouped by type, from the easiest to start with to the most advanced.

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A

Online Listings & Marketplaces

Start here. These sources are public, free or close to it, and you can work them tonight from your phone. The competition is heavier because everyone can see them, so your edge is speed, a clean offer, and knowing what you're looking for before you scroll.

> **Your edge here is speed and a ready offer.**

1. Zillow
2. Facebook Marketplace
3. Craigslist
4. FSBO Listings
5. Expired MLS Listings
6. Bank-Owned (REO) Homes
7. HUD Homes
8. Auction.com

Zillow

01

WHAT IT IS

The largest public home search site. Beyond regular listings, it shows FSBO homes, foreclosures, price history and days on market.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Listings that have sat for a long time or had several price cuts point to a seller who is ready to negotiate.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Set your target zip codes and price range, then save the search with instant alerts.
2. Search for keywords like "as-is," "cash only," "handyman" and "estate."
3. Sort by days on market and look at anything over 60 days or with two or more price drops.
4. Run your numbers (ARV, repairs, rent) before you call, so you can make an offer on the first conversation.
5. Call the listing agent, ask why the seller is selling, and send a written offer the same day.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm a cash buyer and can close in 14 days. I see it's been sitting. What does your seller need to make this happen?"

TOOLS & COST

Free. Use the Zillow app with saved-search alerts.

WATCH OUT

Zestimates are not appraisals. Always run your own comps.

THIS WEEK Save one search with keyword filters in your target zip code and turn on instant alerts.

02

Facebook Marketplace

WHAT IT IS

Facebook's local buy-and-sell board. Owners list houses, land and mobile homes there without an agent.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Sellers who post here often want speed and simplicity, and many have never priced their property against the market.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search Property Rentals and Homes for Sale within your target radius, and search terms like "as is," "cash," "owner finance," "fixer."
2. Save searches and check them at the same time every day. Good posts go fast.
3. Message the owner with a short, friendly note and ask one question about their situation.
4. Move the conversation to a phone call quickly. Deals are made on calls, not in chat.
5. Verify ownership on the county assessor site before you get deep into any deal.

WHAT TO SAY

"Hi, I saw your property. I buy houses as-is and can close fast. Is it still available, and what's got you thinking about selling?"

TOOLS & COST

Free. A Facebook account with a real profile and photo builds trust.

WATCH OUT

Scams are common. Never send money before you verify ownership and use a title company.

THIS WEEK Message five Marketplace sellers in your area this week.

03

Craigslist

WHAT IT IS

An older classifieds site that is still active in many markets, with sections for real estate for sale by owner.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Less competition than Facebook, and older sellers who don't use social media still post here.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Go to Housing → Real Estate for Sale and filter by "owner."
2. Search keywords: "must sell," "as-is," "cash," "estate," "handyman special."
3. Also check "Housing Wanted" for landlords trying to dump problem rentals.
4. Call or email the owner the same day the post goes up.
5. Confirm the owner on the county assessor site before you write an offer.

WHAT TO SAY

"I saw your ad. I buy properties as-is with cash or terms. What's your timeline?"

TOOLS & COST

Free. A saved-search alert tool helps if you check several cities.

WATCH OUT

Fake listings and rental scams are common. Verify everything.

THIS WEEK Check Craigslist's owner listings in your market three days in a row.

FSBO Listings

04

WHAT IT IS

For Sale By Owner: owners selling without an agent, on yard signs, Zillow, FSBO websites and local papers.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

No agent means no one is protecting their price, and many FSBO sellers get tired fast when showings don't turn into offers.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Pull FSBO listings from Zillow (filter "by owner"), FSBO sites and drive-by yard signs.
2. Call within 48 hours. Your goal is to learn their reason for selling and their timeline.
3. If they won't negotiate now, put them on a follow-up list for 30, 60 and 90 days.
4. Offer creative terms (seller financing, subject-to) if they want full price.
5. Write everything down and close through a title company.

WHAT TO SAY

"If I could close on your timeline with no repairs and no commissions, what price would work for you?"

TOOLS & COST

Free to search. A CRM to track follow-ups (GoHighLevel works).

WATCH OUT

Many FSBO sellers overprice at first. Patience and follow-up win these.

THIS WEEK Call three FSBO sellers and put each one into a follow-up sequence.

05

Expired MLS Listings

WHAT IT IS

Homes that were listed with an agent and didn't sell before the listing agreement ended.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

The seller already wanted out, the market already rejected their price, and they may be frustrated with the process.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Ask a realtor partner for expired listings from the last 6 to 12 months in your area.
2. Look up the owner's mailing address and phone with a skip-trace tool.
3. Mail first, then call. Lead with empathy about why it didn't sell.
4. Offer a fast, as-is purchase or terms that solve their problem.
5. If they relist with an agent, stay in touch. Expired twice means very motivated.

WHAT TO SAY

"I noticed your home was on the market and didn't sell. Are you still looking to move, or did plans change?"

TOOLS & COST

A realtor partner for MLS access, a skip-trace service.

WATCH OUT

Agents call expireds aggressively. Check do-not-call rules, and be the calm voice, not the pushy one.

THIS WEEK Ask one realtor for this month's expired list in your target zip codes.

Bank-Owned (REO) Homes

06

WHAT IT IS

Properties the lender took back after a foreclosure auction failed to sell them. Banks list them through REO agents.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Banks don't want to hold real estate. Older REOs often take offers well below list, especially on properties needing repairs.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search "bank owned" or "REO" on Zillow and Realtor.com, and ask agents who specialize in REO.
2. Get proof of funds or a pre-approval ready; banks won't look at offers without it.
3. Offer on properties sitting 30+ days, and expect a counteroffer process.
4. Read the bank's addendum carefully; it often overrides the standard contract.
5. Order an inspection and title search; banks sell as-is.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm a cash buyer with proof of funds. I'd like to submit on the REO at [address]. What's the bank's process?"

TOOLS & COST

Proof of funds, an REO-friendly agent.

WATCH OUT

Bank responses are slow. Submit offers on several at once.

THIS WEEK Find three REOs in your area and run the numbers on each.

HUD Homes

07

WHAT IT IS

Homes owned by the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development after an FHA-insured loan was foreclosed.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

HUD prices are set by appraisal, and unsold homes drop in price over time.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search the official HUD Home Store site by state and county.
2. Know the windows: owner-occupants get first priority; investors can bid after that period ends.
3. Bids must go through a HUD-registered real estate agent.
4. Check the property condition report and attached addenda.
5. Watch for price reductions and re-bid on homes that don't sell.

WHAT TO SAY

(To your agent) "Can you set me up with alerts for HUD homes in these zip codes once they open to investors?"

TOOLS & COST

HUD Home Store (free), a HUD-registered agent.

WATCH OUT

Investor bids are only accepted after the owner-occupant period. Follow the rules exactly.

THIS WEEK Find a HUD-registered agent in your market and set up alerts.

08

Auction.com

WHAT IT IS

The largest online marketplace for foreclosure auctions and bank-owned property sales.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Huge inventory in one place, including trustee sales you'd otherwise have to attend in person.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Create an account and filter by county, property type and auction date.
2. Read the property details and due-diligence materials for each listing.
3. Drive by. Most properties can't be inspected inside.
4. Run a title search; some sales are subject to existing liens.
5. Set your maximum bid before the auction, including buyer's premium, and stick to it.

WHAT TO SAY

(To yourself) "My max is [number] all-in, including the buyer's premium and repairs. I walk at that number."

TOOLS & COST

Free to browse. Funds or financing lined up before bidding.

WATCH OUT

Buyer's premiums, occupied homes and surviving liens can erase your profit.

THIS WEEK Watch five auctions in your county without bidding.

B

People & Partners

Deals travel through relationships. Every person in this section sees distressed or motivated sellers before the public does. You aren't asking them for favors. You're becoming the buyer they call first because you close, you're easy to work with, and you take care of their clients.

> **Be the buyer people call first.**

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Wholesalers

09

WHAT IT IS

Investors who put properties under contract and then assign the contract to a cash buyer for a fee.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

They do the marketing. If you're on their buyers list and you close, they'll send you deals first.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Find wholesalers in Facebook investor groups, at local meetups and on "we buy houses" signs.
2. Get on every buyers list and tell them exactly what you buy: area, price, condition.
3. Respond fast to deals, even when the answer is no, so they keep sending.
4. Verify their numbers yourself. Wholesaler ARVs are often optimistic.
5. Close on time. Reliability is how you become their first call.

WHAT TO SAY

"I buy [type] in [areas] up to [price]. I can close in [days] with cash. Add me to your list?"

TOOLS & COST

A one-page buyer profile you can text to wholesalers.

WATCH OUT

Make sure they actually have the property under contract before you put up a deposit.

THIS WEEK Join three local wholesaler buyers lists this week.

Bird Dogs

10

WHAT IT IS

People who find leads for investors (vacant houses, tired owners) and get paid when a deal closes.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

More eyes in more neighborhoods. Mail carriers, contractors and delivery drivers see distressed homes every day.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Recruit people who drive neighborhoods: contractors, lawn crews, realtors, students.
2. Tell them exactly what a good lead is (vacant, overgrown, boarded up, code notices).
3. Ask for the address, a photo and any info about the owner.
4. Pay a flat finder's fee only when the deal closes, and put it in writing.
5. Thank them publicly and pay fast so they keep looking.

WHAT TO SAY

"If you see a house that looks empty or rundown, text me the address and a photo. If I buy it, you get paid."

TOOLS & COST

A simple written agreement, a text line for submissions.

WATCH OUT

In many states, paying unlicensed people for referrals can raise licensing issues. Check your state's rules.

THIS WEEK Recruit two bird dogs and give them a one-page "what to look for" sheet.

Realtors

WHAT IT IS

Licensed agents who see listings first, know which sellers are motivated and have MLS access.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

A good agent brings you pocket listings, expireds and fixer-uppers before they hit the market.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Look for agents who list probate, REO or older homes in your target area.
2. Show them you're serious: proof of funds, your criteria, how fast you close.
3. Make offers they can present easily, even low ones, so they see you're active.
4. Let them list your flips or manage your resales. That's how they earn from you.
5. Send them referrals and close every deal you can.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm an active investor. I buy as-is homes in [area] and I'll let you list the finished product. Can we work together?"

TOOLS & COST

Proof of funds, a buy-box sheet.

WATCH OUT

Agents can't hide information from their sellers. Keep everything honest and in writing.

THIS WEEK Meet with one investor-friendly agent and give them your buy box.

Facebook Investor Groups

12

WHAT IT IS

Local and national Facebook groups where investors, wholesalers and lenders post deals and resources.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Deals get posted here first, and you can find partners, contractors and lenders in the same place.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search "[your city] real estate investors" and join the active groups.
2. Read the rules, then introduce yourself with what you buy.
3. Turn on notifications for posts in the top two or three groups.
4. Comment and help others. Visibility brings deals to you.
5. Move good leads to phone calls quickly.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm [name], buying [type] in [area]. If you have off-market deals, I can close quickly."

TOOLS & COST

Free. Use the 4DPA app community too.

WATCH OUT

Some posts are bait or double-assigned contracts. Verify before you pay anything.

THIS WEEK Join three local groups and post your introduction.

Title Companies

13

WHAT IT IS

Companies that handle closings, title searches and title insurance.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Title officers see deals fall apart, know who's buying and selling, and often know of distressed situations early.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Pick one or two title companies and run all your closings through them.
2. Ask them about investor-friendly practices: assignments, double closings, quick turns.
3. Let them know what you buy. Title officers do refer deals and buyers.
4. Use them for owner and lien research before you make offers.
5. Be easy to work with: clean paperwork, on-time funds.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'd like to make you my go-to title company. What do you need from me to make my closings smooth?"

TOOLS & COST

A relationship, not a tool.

WATCH OUT

Not every title company handles assignments or double closings. Ask first.

THIS WEEK Call one title company and ask for an investor intro meeting.

Property Managers

14

WHAT IT IS

Companies that manage rentals for owners, many of them out-of-town or tired of being landlords.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

They know which owners are frustrated, behind on repairs or ready to sell, often before the owner says it out loud.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Make a list of local property management companies, especially small ones.
2. Offer to buy from their unhappy owners and keep them as the manager afterward.
3. Ask about properties with high vacancy, repeat repairs or problem tenants.
4. Make offers that let the manager keep the management contract.
5. Stay in touch monthly; owner frustration builds over time.

WHAT TO SAY

"If any of your owners want out, I'll buy and keep you managing the property. Who's struggling right now?"

TOOLS & COST

A short partner pitch and a follow-up calendar.

WATCH OUT

Managers owe duties to their owners. Keep it transparent; never ask them to share private information without permission.

THIS WEEK Call three property managers this week with this offer.

Estate Sale Companies

15

WHAT IT IS

Companies that sell the contents of a home after a death, a move to assisted living or a downsizing.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Once the contents are sold, the family usually needs to sell the house too, and they often want it handled quickly.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Find estate sale companies on estate sale listing sites and in local search results.
2. Introduce yourself as a respectful buyer who can make the house part easy.
3. Visit their sales; you'll meet families and see homes before they list.
4. Offer to refer families to them when you buy a home with contents left inside.
5. Follow up with families gently, after the estate sale, not during.

WHAT TO SAY

"When your families are ready to sell the house, I can buy it as-is on their timeline. I'll send you families who need your service too."

TOOLS & COST

Business cards, a short referral sheet.

WATCH OUT

Families are grieving. Lead with patience and care, not pressure.

THIS WEEK Visit two estate sales this weekend and meet the organizers.

Probate Attorneys & Probate Services

16

WHAT IT IS

Attorneys and service companies that help families settle an estate through the probate court.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Many estates include a house that heirs don't want, can't afford to keep or must sell to divide the estate.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search for probate and estate attorneys in your county.
2. Offer to be a resource: fast, as-is purchases that simplify settling the estate.
3. Learn your state's rules on who can sign (personal representative/executor) and whether court approval is needed.
4. Ask attorneys to share your information with clients who need to sell.
5. Close cleanly, communicate with the attorney, and they'll refer again.

WHAT TO SAY

"When an estate needs to sell a house as-is, I can make that the easy part. Can I be a resource for your clients?"

TOOLS & COST

A one-page "how I help estates" sheet.

WATCH OUT

Only the person with legal authority can sell. Verify it through the court and title company.

THIS WEEK Meet one probate attorney and leave your sheet.

Divorce Attorneys

17

WHAT IT IS

Family-law attorneys handling divorces where a house has to be sold or bought out.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Divorcing couples often need a fast, clean sale so the case can close.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Identify family-law firms in your area.
2. Offer a solution: a quick, as-is sale that removes the house from the dispute.
3. Understand that both spouses usually have to agree and sign.
4. Be neutral. Don't take sides or negotiate with one spouse against the other.
5. Work through the attorneys and title company on every step.

WHAT TO SAY

"When the house is holding up a settlement, I can make a fair cash offer and close on the court's timeline."

TOOLS & COST

A referral sheet for attorneys.

WATCH OUT

Always confirm both owners and the court order before contracting.

THIS WEEK Introduce yourself to two family-law offices.

Bankruptcy Trustees

WHAT IT IS

Court-appointed trustees who sell assets, including real estate, to repay creditors.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Trustees need to sell, and properties are often sold for less than market value to close the case.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Find the trustees for your district on the U.S. Trustee Program website.
2. Ask what properties they're selling and how they prefer to receive offers.
3. Expect court approval and possible overbids before your purchase is final.
4. Have proof of funds ready and be flexible on timing.
5. Build the relationship; trustees handle many cases a year.

WHAT TO SAY

"I buy real estate from bankruptcy estates. How do you prefer to receive offers?"

TOOLS & COST

Proof of funds, a title company familiar with bankruptcy sales.

WATCH OUT

Your accepted offer may still be outbid at the court hearing. Plan for that.

THIS WEEK Email two trustees in your district with your buyer criteria.

Code Compliance Officers

19

WHAT IT IS

City or county inspectors who cite properties for violations: overgrowth, damage, unsafe structures.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

They know every problem property in town, and owners with stacks of violations often want out.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Learn how your city's code enforcement works and how to request records.
2. Introduce yourself as an investor who fixes problem properties.
3. Ask how to get the list of properties with open violations (often a public records request).
4. Contact owners respectfully with an offer to buy as-is.
5. When you buy, fix the violations fast. Your reputation with the city matters.

WHAT TO SAY

"I buy and rehab problem properties. How can I request the list of open code cases?"

TOOLS & COST

A public records request form, a list tracker.

WATCH OUT

Officers can't steer owners to you. Use public records, not favors.

THIS WEEK Submit one public records request for open code cases.

C

Public Records

Courthouses and county offices record life events that often force a sale: lawsuits, liens, divorces, deaths, bankruptcies. These records are public, but most investors never pull them, which is exactly why they work. Names and terms vary by state and county, so learn where your county keeps each one.

> **Pull the records most investors never touch.**

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29 Obituaries

30 Lawsuit Filings

Appraisal District / Assessor Records

20

WHAT IT IS

The county office that values property for taxes. Its website lists owners, mailing addresses, values and sale history.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

It's the free starting point for nearly every list in this guide: who owns what, where they live and how long they've owned it.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Find your county's assessor or appraisal district website (the name varies by state).
2. Learn to search by address, owner name and parcel number.
3. Note owners whose mailing address differs from the property address (absentee).
4. Look for long ownership, low assessed value and no recent sale.
5. Ask whether the county sells bulk data exports; many do for a small fee.

WHAT TO SAY

(To the county) "Do you offer a bulk export of parcel and owner data, and what does it cost?"

TOOLS & COST

Free online search; bulk data may cost a fee.

WATCH OUT

Assessed value is not market value. Use it to find owners, not to price deals.

THIS WEEK Look up ten properties on your street and practice reading the records.

County Clerk / Recorder Records

21

WHAT IT IS

The office that records deeds, mortgages, liens and other documents tied to property.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Recorded documents show debt, transfers and legal trouble: the story behind the owner.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Find your county recorder or clerk's online document search.
2. Search by owner name or parcel to see deeds, mortgages and liens.
3. Watch for new recordings like notices of default, lis pendens and liens.
4. Set a weekly routine to pull new filings by document type.
5. Add matching owners to your lead list and research them further.

WHAT TO SAY

(To the clerk) "Can I search recordings by document type and date range?"

TOOLS & COST

Free or low-cost online search; some counties charge per page.

WATCH OUT

Some counties are only searchable in person. Plan a visit.

THIS WEEK Pull the last week's recorded liens in your county.

Eviction Filings

22

WHAT IT IS

Court cases landlords file to remove tenants for nonpayment or lease violations.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Landlords filing evictions are often losing money and worn out, and some are ready to sell.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Find where your county posts civil or landlord-tenant cases (often the court's online docket).
2. Pull cases filed in the last 30 to 90 days and note the landlord (plaintiff) names.
3. Match landlords to properties using assessor records.
4. Reach out to the landlord, not the tenant, with an offer to buy.
5. Offer options: buy occupied, buy after the eviction, or take over management.

WHAT TO SAY

"I saw you may be dealing with a tough tenant situation. If you'd rather sell than keep fighting it, I can buy as-is."

TOOLS & COST

Court docket search, assessor lookup.

WATCH OUT

Tenant protections vary by city. Understand them before buying an occupied property.

THIS WEEK Pull last month's eviction filings and match five landlords to properties.

Divorce Filings

23

WHAT IT IS

Family-court cases for dissolution of marriage, which are public in many counties.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

When a couple splits, the house often has to be sold so assets can be divided.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Check whether your county's family court records are searchable online.
2. Match the parties' names to property ownership records.
3. Mail a respectful letter offering a simple, fair solution.
4. Be ready to deal with both owners and their attorneys.
5. Never pressure. Timelines often depend on the court, not you.

WHAT TO SAY

"If selling your home would make things simpler right now, I can make a fair cash offer and close when it works for you both."

TOOLS & COST

Court records search, assessor lookup, mail service.

WATCH OUT

This is a sensitive time. Some states restrict access to family-court records. Follow local rules.

THIS WEEK Find out whether divorce filings are public in your county.

Bankruptcy Filings

24

WHAT IT IS

Federal court cases where people or businesses ask for debt relief.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Owners in bankruptcy often have to sell property, but the sale usually needs court or trustee approval.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Learn the basics: Chapter 7 (liquidation) and Chapter 13 (repayment plan) are handled differently.
2. Search filings through the federal PACER system (small per-page fees).
3. Match debtors to property records.
4. Contact the debtor's attorney or the trustee, not just the owner.
5. Expect a court process and plan your timeline around it.

WHAT TO SAY

(To the attorney) "I buy property from bankruptcy estates. Does your client need to sell real estate?"

TOOLS & COST

PACER account, assessor lookup.

WATCH OUT

Never contract directly around the court. Sales without approval can be voided.

THIS WEEK Open a PACER account and learn to search your district.

Lis Pendens Filings

25

WHAT IT IS

A recorded notice that a lawsuit involves a property, often the first public step in a judicial foreclosure.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

It's an early warning. You can reach owners months before the auction while there's still equity to save.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search the county recorder for "lis pendens" filings by date.
2. Identify which are foreclosures versus other disputes.
3. Match properties to owners and check for equity.
4. Mail and call early with options: sale, short sale or a referral to a housing counselor.
5. Follow the case and keep in touch as dates approach.

WHAT TO SAY

"I noticed a filing on your property. If selling would help you avoid foreclosure, I'd like to talk through options."

TOOLS & COST

Recorder search, skip tracing.

WATCH OUT

Many states regulate foreclosure rescue offers. Know your state's rules before contracting.

THIS WEEK Pull the last 30 days of lis pendens filings.

Mechanic's Liens

26

WHAT IT IS

Liens filed by contractors or suppliers who weren't paid for work on a property.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

An unpaid contractor means a stalled project, a cash-strapped owner or both.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search the recorder for mechanic's liens filed in the last few months.
2. Look up the property and check for multiple liens.
3. Reach out to the owner with an offer that pays off the lien at closing.
4. Talk to the contractor, too; they may know the full story.
5. Get a title search to see every lien before you offer.

WHAT TO SAY

"I buy properties as-is, including unfinished projects. I can pay off what's owed at closing."

TOOLS & COST

Recorder search, title company.

WATCH OUT

Liens get paid at closing. Your price must account for them.

THIS WEEK Find five properties with recent mechanic's liens.

Judgment Liens

27

WHAT IT IS

Liens created when someone loses a lawsuit and owes money, attached to property they own.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Owners with judgments often need cash, and the lien makes it harder for them to refinance.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search the recorder for recorded judgments or abstracts of judgment.
2. Match debtors to property they own.
3. Check equity: home value minus mortgages and liens.
4. Offer a solution that pays the judgment at closing.
5. Work through the title company to get payoffs.

WHAT TO SAY

"If selling would help you clear what's owed, I can buy as-is and close quickly."

TOOLS & COST

Recorder search, title company payoffs.

WATCH OUT

Some judgments may be negotiable; get payoffs in writing.

THIS WEEK Pull judgments recorded in the last 60 days.

Probate Filings

28

WHAT IT IS

Court cases opened after someone dies to settle their estate.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Many heirs live elsewhere, don't want the house or need to sell it to divide the estate.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search your county probate court for new cases.
2. Identify the personal representative (executor) and their attorney.
3. Check whether the estate includes real estate.
4. Send a respectful letter, then follow up after a few weeks.
5. Close through the attorney and title company with proper authority.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm sorry for your loss. When you're ready, I can buy the property as-is so you don't have to deal with repairs or showings."

TOOLS & COST

Probate court search, mail service.

WATCH OUT

Lead with compassion. Timelines depend on the court.

THIS WEEK Pull last month's probate filings in your county.

Obituaries

29

WHAT IT IS

Death notices in newspapers and funeral home websites.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

They can identify estates before a probate case is opened.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Track obituaries in your target area.
2. Match the deceased to property records.
3. Wait a respectful amount of time before reaching out.
4. Find the next of kin through probate filings when they appear.
5. Offer help, not pressure.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm sorry for your family's loss. If you need to sell the home at some point, I'm here to help on your timeline."

TOOLS & COST

Newspaper or funeral home sites, assessor lookup.

WATCH OUT

Never contact families during the funeral period. Respect matters more than speed.

THIS WEEK Practice matching three obituaries to property records (no outreach yet).

Lawsuit Filings

30

WHAT IT IS

Civil court cases against property owners: debt collection, contract disputes and more.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

An owner facing a lawsuit may need to sell before a judgment hits.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search your county's civil court docket for new cases.
2. Focus on defendants who own property.
3. Check for related liens and equity.
4. Offer a sale as one option to resolve their situation.
5. Track the case and follow up.

WHAT TO SAY

"If selling your property would help you resolve things, I can make a fair offer and close quickly."

TOOLS & COST

Court docket search, assessor lookup.

WATCH OUT

Many lawsuits have nothing to do with selling. Use this as one layer, not the whole picture.

THIS WEEK Pull civil filings for one week and count how many defendants own property.

D

Motivated Seller Lists

A list is a group of owners who share a reason to sell. You can build some for free from county data, or buy them from a list provider. The money is in stacking: an owner who shows up on two or three lists at once is far more likely to sell than someone on one.

> **Stack lists. Two or three hits beats one.**

31 Absentee Owners

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33 Vacant Properties

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40 Tax-Delinquent Properties

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Absentee Owners

31

WHAT IT IS

Owners whose mailing address is different from the property address (landlords, heirs, people who moved away).

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Distance makes managing harder, and many absentee owners hold properties they no longer want.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Build the list from assessor data or buy it from a list provider.
2. Filter for out-of-state owners and long ownership.
3. Skip trace for phone numbers and emails.
4. Mail first, then call or text where allowed.
5. Follow up for months. Timing is everything.

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm reaching out about your property at [address]. Have you thought about selling?"

TOOLS & COST

Assessor data or a list provider, a skip-trace service.

WATCH OUT

Follow do-not-call and texting consent rules for every outreach.

THIS WEEK Pull 100 absentee owners in one zip code.

Tired Landlords

32

WHAT IT IS

Landlords who've owned rentals for years and are ready to stop dealing with tenants and repairs.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

They often own the property free and clear and want simplicity more than top dollar.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Start with absentee owners and filter for 10+ years of ownership.
2. Add eviction filings and code violations to find the most frustrated.
3. Offer options: cash, seller financing or buying with tenants in place.
4. Talk about relief, not price.
5. Follow up regularly; the next bad tenant may be the turning point.

WHAT TO SAY

"If you're ready to step back from being a landlord, I can buy with tenants in place, and we can talk terms that keep income coming to you."

TOOLS & COST

List provider filters, a CRM.

WATCH OUT

Seller financing needs proper documents. Use an attorney or title company.

THIS WEEK Build a list of 50 owners holding rentals 10+ years.

Vacant Properties

33

WHAT IT IS

Houses with no one living in them: no utilities, mail piling up, overgrown yards.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Vacant homes cost owners money every month and are often tied to an estate or move.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Drive neighborhoods and note signs of vacancy ("driving for dollars").
2. Use list providers that flag USPS vacancy.
3. Look up owners in assessor records.
4. Mail and skip trace the owner.
5. Check for code violations and liens; they add urgency.

WHAT TO SAY

"I noticed your property at [address] looks empty. Would you consider selling it as-is?"

TOOLS & COST

A driving-for-dollars app, a list provider.

WATCH OUT

Never enter a vacant property without the owner's permission.

THIS WEEK Drive one neighborhood for an hour and log every vacant home.

Code Violation Lists

34

WHAT IT IS

Properties with open code-enforcement cases: unsafe structures, junk, overgrowth.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Violations bring fines and stress. Owners who can't fix them often want to sell.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Request open code cases from your city or county (often a public records request).
2. Sort by number and type of violations.
3. Look up owners and check equity.
4. Reach out with an as-is offer that takes the problem off their hands.
5. Budget for repairs and fines in your price.

WHAT TO SAY

"I buy homes as-is, including ones with city violations. You won't have to fix anything."

TOOLS & COST

Public records requests, assessor lookup.

WATCH OUT

Fines may stay with the property. Check before closing.

THIS WEEK Request your city's open code violations list.

Utility Shut-Off Lists

35

WHAT IT IS

Properties where water or power has been shut off for nonpayment or vacancy.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

A shutoff often signals a vacant home or an owner in serious financial trouble.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Ask whether your city publishes water shutoff or vacancy lists; some do through code enforcement.
2. Check list providers that track utility status where legally available.
3. Look up the owners and confirm vacancy by driving by.
4. Reach out respectfully with an as-is offer.
5. Combine with tax delinquency and code violations for priority.

WHAT TO SAY

"I buy homes in any condition. If the property's become a burden, I can help."

TOOLS & COST

City records, list provider.

WATCH OUT

Access to utility data is limited and varies widely. Use only legal sources.

THIS WEEK Ask your city whether shutoff or vacancy records are public.

Pre-Foreclosure Lists

36

WHAT IT IS

Owners who are behind on mortgage payments and have received an official notice from the lender.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

They have a deadline, and a sale can protect their credit and their equity.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Pull notices of default or lis pendens from the county, or buy a pre-foreclosure list.
2. Check equity. Little equity may mean a short sale.
3. Reach out early and often; owners are getting many letters.
4. Offer options and refer them to a HUD-approved housing counselor if a sale isn't right.
5. Close through a title company before the sale date.

WHAT TO SAY

"I know you have options. If selling makes sense, I can close before the sale date and protect what equity you have."

TOOLS & COST

County records or list provider, skip tracing.

WATCH OUT

Foreclosure rescue rules are strict in many states. Know them before you contract.

THIS WEEK Pull 30 days of pre-foreclosure filings in your county.

Notice of Default Lists

37

WHAT IT IS

A recorded notice of default (NOD) is the formal first step in many non-judicial foreclosures, including in California.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

It starts the clock. Owners now have a fixed period before a sale can be scheduled.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Search recorder filings for notices of default by date.
2. Calculate when a notice of sale could be filed in your state.
3. Check equity using assessor values and recorded loans.
4. Reach out with clear, honest options.
5. Track every lead in your CRM with the key dates.

WHAT TO SAY

"I saw a notice was filed on your home. If you'd like to talk about selling before things go further, I'm here."

TOOLS & COST

Recorder search, CRM.

WATCH OUT

California has specific rules for buying homes in foreclosure. Learn them first.

THIS WEEK Pull this month's notices of default in your county.

Free-and-Clear Owners

38

WHAT IT IS

Owners with no mortgage on their property.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

With no loan, they have the most flexibility: cash discounts, seller financing or lease options.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Pull a free-and-clear list from a list provider or match assessor and recorder data.
2. Combine with long ownership and absentee status.
3. Lead with seller financing. It gives them income without a tax hit all at once.
4. Explain options in plain language.
5. Document everything with an attorney or title company.

WHAT TO SAY

"Since you own it outright, we could set up monthly payments to you instead of a lump sum. Would that interest you?"

TOOLS & COST

List provider, attorney for seller-financing documents.

WATCH OUT

Check for unrecorded loans or liens with a title search.

THIS WEEK Pull 50 free-and-clear owners with 15+ years of ownership.

High-Equity Owners

39

WHAT IT IS

Owners whose property is worth much more than what they owe.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Equity gives you room to buy below market and still give the seller a good outcome.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Use list providers that estimate equity, then verify with recorded loans.
2. Combine with a motivation factor (absentee, vacant, tax delinquent).
3. Run comps and repair costs before you call.
4. Make offers that solve a problem, not just the lowest number.
5. Follow up for months.

WHAT TO SAY

"I can buy as-is, close on your timeline and handle everything. Would you like a no-obligation offer?"

TOOLS & COST

List provider, comps tool.

WATCH OUT

Equity without motivation rarely sells at a discount. Always stack a reason.

THIS WEEK Pull 100 high-equity owners and stack one motivation list on top.

Tax-Delinquent Properties

40

WHAT IT IS

Properties where the owner is behind on property taxes.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Unpaid taxes can lead to a tax sale, which pushes owners to act.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Request the delinquent tax list from the county treasurer or tax collector.
2. Sort by years and amount delinquent.
3. Look up owners and check for other distress.
4. Reach out with an offer that pays the taxes at closing.
5. Track the county's tax sale timeline.

WHAT TO SAY

"If the back taxes have become a burden, I can buy the property and pay them off at closing."

TOOLS & COST

County tax collector, assessor lookup.

WATCH OUT

Redemption periods and tax sale rules vary a lot by state.

THIS WEEK Request your county's delinquent tax list.

Foreclosure Postings

41

WHAT IT IS

Public notices of upcoming foreclosure sales, posted in newspapers, at the courthouse or on trustee websites.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

It's the last chance to buy before auction, when owners are most motivated.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Find where your county posts notices of sale (legal newspapers, trustee websites).
2. List properties and sale dates.
3. Contact owners quickly with clear options.
4. Prepare to bid at auction if no deal is reached.
5. Confirm postponements with the trustee before the sale.

WHAT TO SAY

"I know the sale date is close. If a quick sale would help, I can move fast."

TOOLS & COST

Legal notices, trustee websites.

WATCH OUT

Timelines are short. Have funds and title ready.

THIS WEEK Find where notices of sale are posted in your county.

E

Auctions & Tax Sales

This is where properties go when everything else has failed. Prices can be very low, but the rules are strict: cash or certified funds, little or no inspection, and sometimes liens that survive the sale. Watch several auctions before you bid at one.

> **Watch before you bid. Know what survives the sale.**

42 Sheriff's Sales

43 Courthouse Auctions

44 Struck-Off / Tax-Forfeited Properties

Sheriff's Sales

42

WHAT IT IS

Court-ordered auctions run by the sheriff, usually after a judicial foreclosure or judgment.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

Properties can sell for well below market, especially when few bidders show up.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Find your county sheriff's sale schedule and rules.
2. Research each property: title, liens, occupancy and condition from the outside.
3. Know the payment terms: deposit amount, deadline and accepted funds.
4. Attend a few sales before you bid.
5. Set your max bid and stick to it.

WHAT TO SAY

(To yourself) "I know every lien on this property, my repair cost and my exit. My max is [number]."

TOOLS & COST

Sheriff's office website, title search, cash or certified funds.

WATCH OUT

Some liens survive the sale, and occupants may need to be removed legally.

THIS WEEK Attend one sheriff's sale as an observer.

Courthouse Auctions

43

WHAT IT IS

Foreclosure and trustee sales held on the courthouse steps or online.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

This is the final stop before a property goes back to the bank, and the price can be right.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Get the sale schedule from trustees, the county or online auction sites.
2. Pull title on every property you plan to bid on.
3. Bring the required funds (often cashier's checks).
4. Watch the bidding and learn who the regulars are.
5. After you win, follow your state's process for occupied properties.

WHAT TO SAY

(To the trustee) "What are the bidding requirements and the accepted forms of payment?"

TOOLS & COST

Cashier's checks, title search, a trustee contact list.

WATCH OUT

You usually can't inspect inside. Budget for the unknown.

THIS WEEK Watch one courthouse auction from start to finish.

Struck-Off / Tax-Forfeited Properties

44

WHAT IT IS

Properties that didn't sell at a tax sale and were struck off to the county or state. The name and process vary by state.

WHY DEALS COME FROM HERE

The county doesn't want to hold them, so many are sold later through over-the-counter or special sales at low prices.

HOW TO WORK IT

1. Ask your county treasurer or tax office what happens to unsold tax properties.
2. Request the list of struck-off, adjudicated or forfeited properties.
3. Research title carefully; some come with clouded title.
4. Learn the purchase process and any redemption rights.
5. Plan for a quiet title action if needed.

WHAT TO SAY

(To the county) "What's the process for buying properties that didn't sell at the tax sale?"

TOOLS & COST

County tax office, title attorney.

WATCH OUT

Clouded title can make resale hard. Know the cost to clear it first.

THIS WEEK Ask your county whether it has struck-off or forfeited properties for sale.

PUT IT TOGETHER

Your weekly lead system

Deals don't come from one great source. They come from a simple routine you repeat every week. Here's a starting rhythm you can adjust as you learn what works in your market.

Monday · Pull

Pull new county filings (notices of default, lis pendens, probate, liens) and refresh your saved searches.

Tuesday · Stack

Match new names against your other lists. Move anyone on two or more lists to the top of your queue.

Wednesday · Reach out

Mail, call and message your top leads, following calling and texting rules.

Thursday · Relationships

Check in with one realtor, wholesaler, attorney, property manager or title officer every week.

Friday · Follow up

Work your follow-up list. Most deals close after several touches, not the first one.

Weekend · Drive

Drive one neighborhood for an hour and log vacant or distressed homes.

TRACK FIVE NUMBERS

Leads added · Conversations had · Offers made · Contracts signed · Deals closed. Track them weekly by source so you know what's working, then put more time into those sources.

NEXT STEP

Bring your first list to class.

Pick three sources from this guide, pull your first list this week, and bring it to a live session. Questions go to your mentorship channel or info@4datapoints.com.